

**Supporting children's emotional wellbeing and learning
development during school transitions through play: Teachers'
perceptions on approaching children's entry to Key Stage 1 (KS1)
in England.**

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Abstract

Play-based learning can be defined as a child-led, imaginative and exploratory strategy for learning which incorporates play and education within school settings (Briggs and Hansen, 2012; EEF, 2025b). This study investigates how play-based learning can be implemented in KS1 and how play may support emotional wellbeing and learning development during transition to Year 1. A qualitative method was used to gather findings and analysis data. Three teachers from one primary school in Eastern England were interviewed using a semi structured approach to understand how play-based learning was utilised in their classroom environments and on a school wide level. They also discussed how the transition from Reception to KS1 can be supported. Although the sample size was small, differences emerged between the participants' views of play-based learning, implying that play can be implemented in varying ways. The teachers' perceptions offer insights into the potential enactments of play-based learning and their role in reducing challenges in transition to Year 1 that many children in England face (Fisher, 2009; Nicholson, 2019).

Key words: EYFS; Key Stage 1 Transition; Play-based Learning; Emotional Wellbeing; School Readiness; Teacher Perceptions

Background and rationale

Around 600,000 children complete the Early Years Foundation Stage (EYFS) and transition to Key Stage 1 (KS1), which includes Years 1 and 2, each year in England (DfE, 2025a).

Research indicates that this transition, while new and exciting for many children (Dockett and Perry, 2007), can also be challenging when navigating reduced playtimes and new routines (Nicholson, 2019).

O'Connor (2017) describes certain children who are statistically more likely to struggle with transition to Year 1, including those with learning difficulties, low confidence and summer-born children. Fisher (2009) explains that the transition to Year 1 is often too abrupt because of the shift from play-based learning to formalised, adult-led learning. Several researchers discuss how schools must 'bridge the gap' between EYFS and KS1 to make the transition smoother (Peters, 2014; Huser, Dockett and Perry, 2016; Nicholson, 2019). Supporting children at this point of transition is vital to enhance emotional regulation and self-confidence, which aids children in navigating successful educational experiences (Education Endowment Foundation, 2025a). Creating a positive and playful classroom environment during transition can help children feel emotionally secure and ready to learn (Fisher, 2020).

My interest in this topic stems from my own experience of volunteering in a Reception classroom. I witnessed the anxieties children felt about transitioning to Year one, alongside teachers' concerns around their readiness for more formalised learning. I was informed that

the school wanted to implement more play-based learning moving forward into Year 1 and 2 to combat the worries felt by children and support their learning.

This study explores how the transition from Reception to Year 1 affects children's wellbeing and learning development. In the literature review the role of play-based learning and its link to transition is discussed. Evidence from the semi-structured interviews conducted from one primary school in Eastern England is then presented. The teachers elaborate on how they perceive and apply play in their classrooms and how they view the connection between play and transition. Most studies on transition refer to starting primary school or secondary school, but my research focuses on the shift to KS1, an under researched area. Ultimately, this research looks to address the gap between theory, policy and classroom practice to promote positive transitions for children in school.

My research explores the following question:

- How do teachers in EYFS and Year 1 perceive the role of play-based learning in promoting children's wellbeing during the transition to Year One in a Primary school in Eastern England?

Literature review

Poor wellbeing and school readiness

Formal, compulsory schooling in England begins at the age of five, although many children begin Reception at the age of four (UK Government school admissions, 2026). Today learning can start earlier in nursery and home settings, illustrating the growing view in England that children should be ‘school ready’ (DfE, 2025b). This term is “*defined as the degree to which a child is prepared to thrive in school cognitively, socially and emotionally*” (Davies, Cooper and Bains, 2020, p.338). Children's transition to formal schooling is often a critical period for supporting emerging wellbeing issues, as increasingly children begin to experience a rise in mental health problems and potential unmet needs (Maclean and Law, 2022). Therefore, schools now undertake a pastoral role of care for children including supplying free school meals and in safeguarding (DfE, 2025c; DfE, 2025d).

This role aligns with the UK government's recent emphasis on school readiness policy, aiming for 75% of children in England to be school ready by 2028 (Metcalf and Davison, 2025). Critically, research suggests that many children are not socially ready and lack the self care skills needed to enter school (Kindred Squared, 2024). Children seem to be insufficiently supported potentially due to a lack of pedagogically appropriate play-based learning, which many schools cannot provide due to curriculum pressures and lack of resources (McInnes, 2021). Therefore, while policy frames school readiness as an overarching expectation for all children, individual developmental differences are overlooked (Kay, 2021). This places the

onus of school readiness onto the child which raises concerns about wellbeing during transition (Kay, 2021).

Play-based learning

Play-based learning is a core element within the EYFS, allowing children to learn in an engaging way (Ofsted, 2015; McInnes, 2021; EEF, 2025b). The EYFS statutory framework (2025b) states that “*children learn through play*” (p. 7), articulating its central importance in education. An EYFS classroom can reflect a home-like environment to ease the transition from the domestic setting to a more formal one (DfE, 2025a). Play can be used in multiple ways including to support literacy and numeracy (Briggs and Hansen, 2012). Continuous provision can be used, meaning resources are available all the time for children to use and enhanced provision, where extra resources are provided for children which link to the curriculum and challenge the child (Sutherland, 2006).

Pedagogical play means using play in a purposeful way to support children's learning, socialisation and emotional resilience (Moore, 2014). Many influential theorists such as Rousseau, Dewey and Froebel argued that children learn most naturally through play, shaping the way we think about early years pedagogy today (Moore, 2014). Although the EEF (2025b) reports that play-based learning seems to have small attainment benefits, this framing may reflect both the limited studies conducted into the approach and the narrow way in which play was measured. Using a standardised measurement of attainment as influenced by play

might not fully explore the social, emotional and developmental benefits play-based learning can provide (Whitebread et al., 2017). Other researchers argue that play-based learning should continue in KS1 as it is still developmentally appropriate in supporting active learning and collaboration with peers, supported by clear learning outcomes from teachers (McInnes, 2021; Ofsted, 2024). The opposing views of how play-based learning should be implemented and until what age may explain why the practice continues to be contested in regard to its necessity within KS1 (Samuelsson and Carlsson, 2008). The EEF (2025b) does report that when play-based learning is well implemented there is an average improvement in learning outcomes of four months which implies that its effectiveness may be based upon the quality of the teachers training in the area or the quality of resources available to support play. While play-based learning is well-researched within the EYFS, fewer studies examine its role in KS1 or how teachers use it to support transitions while meeting curriculum goals.

Transition to Key Stage One (KS1)

Transition from EYFS and KS1 is a significant stage for every child and one that is both exciting and emotionally taxing (Jun, Meissel and Cooper, 2025). Research displays that children can struggle with separation anxiety, difficulty adjusting to a highly structured timetable and conforming to behavioural expectations in a new environment (Wildenger and McIntyre, 2011).

Research displays that when a positive transition is achieved, children experience prolonged success in their educational attainment (Harper, 2016). However, if a child's transition is not properly supported, their academic, emotional and social skills can be compromised significantly (Nicholson, 2019). This conveys the importance for continuity and well planned support between EYFS and KS1 to better support children through this transition.

A major challenge children face during the transition to KS1 is the reduction of play-based learning. According to Savage (2026) during a parliamentary debate on the Key Stage 1 curriculum, “*England is now an outlier in the United Kingdom as the only nation with no statutory expectation that play-based learning should continue beyond age five*”. This statement highlights the “*discontinuity*” (Fisher, 2011, p.32) present in English primary schools between EYFS and KS1, with children abruptly transitioning out of play-based learning into a formalised academic approach. As noted by the Department of Education (2025a), the Foundation stage is presented as a building block to get ‘ready’ for Year 1. As a consequence, play becomes part of a set stage rather than an ongoing pedagogical approach. This results in a devaluation of play in favour of more formalised academic learning which may negatively affect transition.

Research indicates that maintaining a play-based pedagogy can help bridge the gap between EYFS and KS1 and reduce feelings of stress for children (Brostrom, 2005; O’Kane 2016,). When bridging is unsuccessful or absent, children can feel ill-equipped to deal with the new demands of the Year 1 learning environment which affects their confidence and engagement socially and with their learning (Dunlop and Fabian 2007; Huser, Dockett, and Perry 2016). A potential reason for transitional issues is that the Early Childhood Education and Care (ECEC) system, the regulated care structure for children birth to five, and Compulsory School Education (CSE) are not compatible in their current forms, which creates tension when children move to KS1 (Karila and Rantavuori, 2014). Here, children move from learning through forms of play to learning for the purpose of assessment (Samuelsson and Carlsson, 2008, Howe, 2016). While this transition is necessary as children grow and progress in their learning, policy should be mindful of the need to avoid a disjointed leap for

children which could impact negatively on their future view on education through unreadiness (Evans, 2025).

To minimise disconnectedness between the stages of school and promote effective transitions, the Year 1 teacher can spend time in EYFS classrooms, getting to know the students well and engaging in handover meetings with the EYFS teachers (Quirk and Pettett, 2021). Year 1 teachers can also extend the EYFS timetable in the first few weeks of the year to allow children to familiarise themselves with the new teacher and their behavioural expectations, allowing for a sense of normalcy and a smoother transition (Quirk and Pettett, 2021). Extending the EYFS curriculum into Year 1 can be done practically through designing continuous provision activities throughout the classroom, where children can pick from a range of playful and educationally engaging activities in any order they choose (Bryce-Clegg, 2017).

Nicholson (2019) conducted a small-scale study regarding teachers and pupils' perspectives of pedagogical discontinuity when transitioning to Year 1. When a play-based pedagogy was incorporated into the transition, it promoted children's wellbeing, emotional competency, cognition and social development (Nicholson, 2019; Whitebread et. al., 2017). While many teachers in the study wanted to continue a play-based pedagogy in Year 1, they highlighted that accountability pressures were felt strongly, so much so that it became hard to balance the pedagogy with national curriculum objectives (Nicholson, 2019; Nolan and Paatsch, 2018). Additionally, implementing play-based learning can be misunderstood as simply allowing children to do what they like without understanding its importance in learning development and enhancement of various skills (Nicholson, 2019; Nolan and Paatsch, 2018).

A slow pedagogy may be needed to aid this transition to Year 1, where play can be open-ended and a matter of free choice through continuous provision (Clark, 2022). Frequently, as soon as children enter Year 1, playtime is only allowed once work is completed or during break times (Clark, 2022). A hurried attitude to playtime in favour of the learning goals, assessment and accountability mean educational opportunities and times of extended exploration may be overlooked and dismissed as meaningless (Clark, 2022). International perspectives on the continuation of play further highlight issues within the current system in England. In many Nordic countries, the school start is delayed until the age of six and these countries report higher literacy scores which could be an indication of a benefit of extended play (Laaninen, Kulic and Erola, 2024). Critically, the OECD (2019) reports that these results may be due to a range of socio-economic factors, suggesting that success cannot solely be based on play.

Play-based learning in KS1

While play-based learning is well regarded as important and necessary in EYFS, its role in KS1 is more controversial. Many researchers have found that play is significantly reduced as children enter KS1 despite the fact it is considered developmentally appropriate to continue until at least age seven (Fisher, 2011; McInnes, 2021). Although some view play-based

learning with scepticism, asserting that play and learning should remain separate entities within school (Fesseha & Pyle, 2016), evidence displays that extending play in KS1 is socially and developmentally beneficial (McInnes, 2021). However, little research has been conducted surrounding how play-based pedagogies can be successfully implemented into KS1 while teachers aim to meet accountability and curriculum requirements.

Moreover, some worry that extending play into KS1 would disrupt children's Good level of Development (GLD) scores (Nicholson and Hendry, 2022). The term is used to describe children who have reached an expected standard of development in several social and academic goals by the end of Reception (Nicholson and Hendry, 2022). It is agreed that relying on play as a short-term intervention system is unsustainable, which could lead to children facing challenges in GLD (Nicholson and Hendry, 2022). Nicholson and Hendry (2022) examined the implementation of a play-based pedagogy in a school with children who had lower than expected GLD scores. They found the school relied heavily on the score, grouping children according to ability, leading to major behavioural issues in the group with highly complex needs. There was a lack of understanding among staff regarding the play-based approach, conveying how more training was needed before wider school implementation. Effective instillation of play-based learning is only possible with a common pedagogical approach between class teachers and long-term commitment by school leads, which this school seemed to lack (Fisher, 2011; Jay and Knaus, 2018). Kay (2021) argues that the GLD measure creates a tension with the EYFS framework's assertion that all children develop in various ways and at different paces (Department for Education, 2025a). Consequently, children who do not meet the expected standard may be seen as falling behind compared to their peers, rather than being recognised for their individual pace of development.

Some studies highlighted a hybrid approach to play-based learning, where formal teacher led lessons are combined with continuous provision periods for children to explore autonomously. Quirk and Pettett (2021) discovered that play-based learning in Year 1 led to high engagement and increased proficiency in literacy and numeracy. However, teachers faced challenges when adapting to the open-ended learning style of continuous provision while ensuring they followed curriculum goals. Additionally, teachers noted that the students who needed to be challenged had missed opportunities to extend their learning. This needed to be addressed within continuous provision, where tasks were adjusted to allow for extensions in learning, so an extra challenge would always be available. Ultimately, teachers liked the change, and many stated they would never go back to teaching without play-based learning in Year 1.

Policy developments in play and transition in England

While policy frameworks in England emphasises the use of play in EYFS, there is research to suggest there are barriers to play-based learning during the transition to KS1. An Ofsted (2018) report entitled *Bold Beginnings*, found that a smooth transition to Year 1 was challenging due to EYFS learning goals being incompatible with ever increasing national curriculum and safeguarding expectations. This disconnect when children transition to KS1 means a child's wellbeing and their academic, emotional and social skills can be compromised significantly (Nicholson, 2019). BERA (2017) also noted that play is often usurped by more formalised intentions of education and that children's interests are important to recognise in play and learning. It is also noted that when play is implemented it is often not seen as a form of learning and not built upon by educators during their teaching (BERA,

2017). This displays how misinterpretations and the contested nature of the importance of play affects its implementation. More research is needed to develop an appropriate play-based framework in school settings.

Theoretical and developmental background to transition and play

Key child developmental theorists aid the understanding of how play can support transition. Vygotsky's (1978) theory of the zone of proximal development (ZPD), highlights the gap between what a child can do independently and what they can achieve with guidance.

Although Vygotsky (1978) did not directly recommend play-based learning, his theory of ZPD reinforces the idea that play is not a separate entity to learning but supports child development, scaffolded by a knowledgeable adult. Play allows children to develop in areas such as emotional self-regulation much earlier than in other tasks which do not involve play (Bodrova, Germeroth and Leong, 2013). While Vygotsky's theory aligns with play-based learning, utilising this approach in mainstream primary school classrooms may be challenging due to large class sizes and accountability pressures.

On the other hand, while Vygotsky's socio-cultural theory is relevant, schooling and the national curriculum in England today reflect Piaget's (1952) age stages of development more closely, with children transitioning through year groups based on age (Aubrey and Riley, 2023). This approach can be challenging for children during transition as varying levels of socio- emotional development are not accounted for (Bourn et. al, 2017). As a result, learning becomes increasingly more formalised in Year 1 and opportunities for play are reduced which has been criticised for ignoring the different developmental paces and emotional readiness children feel (Bourn et. al, 2017). In comparison, Vygotsky's (1978) approach

would allow children to develop at their own pace through increased opportunities for play and exploration so that the shift into Year 1 is not so abrupt.

Along with cognitive development theory, attachment theory also supports having continuity and ensuring emotional security for children during transitions. Teachers can provide secure relationships which create a stable and consistent space for children in school, reducing apprehension, stress and anxiety in children and allowing more focus on learning (Bowlby, 1969, Ainsworth et al., 2015). This theory displays the importance of sensitive care towards young children to ensure their school transitions are positive life events and developmentally appropriate.

The teacher's role in transition and facilitating play

Teachers play a central role in supporting children in experiencing a smooth and positive transition into KS1 (Fisher, 2020). Transitions should be framed to children by the teacher as a new, exciting adventure (Fisher, 2020). Collaboration between EYFS staff and Year 1 staff allows teachers to plan around children's interests and note their strengths and challenges (Fisher, 2020). This can reduce assumptions and support individualised learning for each child (Fisher, 2020). Research displays that many teachers want play to continue into KS1 (Nicholson 2019; Fisher, 2020).

Effective transition involves positive and deep connections being built between school staff, children and parents. Some schools employ innovative strategies to ease the tensions of transition for children. Fisher (2020) found that some schools have Year 1 teachers visit Reception classrooms in advance of the new school year. This allows for teachers and children to build relationships. Some schools also implement a rolling class system, where the Reception teacher will continue to teach Year 1. This enhances familiarity for children, promoting emotional security and continuity of expectations (Fisher, 2020).

Teachers can use play to enhance learning in KS1 but may face various constraints within school. Teachers can set clear objectives when using play so educational needs are met (Li and Kangas, 2024). Teachers can also provide varying levels of guidance, acting as a play mate, team member, leader or observer in play (Li and Kangas, 2024). A playful pedagogy is welcomed by many teachers, but they face the pressure of accountability and curriculum demands (Nicholson, 2019). This tension may mean teachers feel restricted by how much play they can introduce. Additionally, playtime is often used as a reward when children finish their work which reinforces a play-work divide and reduces children's interest in curriculum content (Nicholson, 2019). When play is used to aid learning it can promote deeper engagement, allowing children to experiment and create complex narratives (Fisher, 2011).

Methodology

Research design

A qualitative research design using semi-structured interviews with teachers was implemented in this study. Qualitative research is utilised to explore meanings, experiences and perceptions in depth which allows rich contextual data to emerge rather than measurable outcomes (Creswell and Creswell, 2018). This approach was most suited when investigating teachers' perceptions of play-based learning and transition for children from EYFS to Year 1 as it allowed for extensive, detailed insights that a quantitative approach could not obtain (Merriam and Tisdell, 2016).

Sample

Three teachers were sampled from one primary school in Eastern England which I had worked for previously and observed their play-based learning practices in person.

The school in which I chose to interview teachers takes a rare approach within England as it actively incorporates continuous and enhanced play provision throughout Year 1 and Year 2, when many stop in Reception. The information gathered was compared and analysed against the existing literature.

Participants were selected using a purposive sampling method, allowing focus on a small sample of individuals who could contribute relevant insights connected to the research question (Given, 2008). The deputy head teacher acted as a gatekeeper and provided a list of teachers who had expressed interest in taking part. Teachers were contacted by email and

provided with an information sheet and consent form outlining the purposes of the study (Appendix 2 and 3). Written informed consent was obtained before the interviews began. All the interviews were audio recorded with the participants permission and then transcribed afterwards for analysis. Participants were selected based on their current or previous experience teaching EYFS or Year 1, making their views relevant to the study because of their informed perspectives of play-based learning and its role in supporting children's wellbeing during transition. Each teacher was given a pseudonym and all other identifying information was concealed.

A challenge during this process was teacher availability, which meant waiting for a few weeks before interviews could take place and moving them online. Interviewing remotely meant rapport was harder to obtain than an in-person interview may have allowed.

Data collection

Semi-structured interviews were used to collect data so that rich and detailed responses could be obtained (Merriam and Tisdell, 2016). The method allowed me to ask specific, open-ended questions while also providing flexibility to ask follow up questions to gain further insights (Merriam and Tisdell, 2016; Flick, 2018). Previous studies exploring teachers' perspectives on school transitions and play, such as Erkan and Elkin et. al (2021) and Pyle and Danniels (2017), demonstrate the rich detail that can be obtained through this method.

Interview schedule

Interview questions within my guide (Appendix 4) were based on my main research question and a sequence of six key questions was used to guide interviews (Flick, 2018). Interviews lasted between 20-30 minutes and were conducted online. I designed questions using Patton's (2015) guide to asking good questions during qualitative interviews, using them to understand the experience of the teachers supporting students' wellbeing during the transition and reflections on their pedagogical practice. Although the same main questions were asked to all participants to allow comparability, I addressed contextual differences between each teacher's year group by asking follow up questions that were specific to the teacher's experience.

Data analysis

Once interview transcripts were collected, I used Braun and Clarke (2022) thematic analysis to create themes related to my research question. I used inductive coding, looking through the data and allowing themes to naturally emerge (Liu, 2016). Inductive coding reduced the risk of researcher bias and allowed for insights from teacher's classroom experience to be themed. I used this type of coding instead of the deductive approach, where predetermined codes are found (Fife and Gossner, 2024). Examples of codes I discovered included anxiety reduction, emotional regulation through play, sense of security and familiarity, confidence and belonging which I grouped into a theme about play being used as a tool in this school to aid the transition process for children. Five findings were discovered and are discussed below.

Trustworthiness of data

To create a trustworthy study, I considered credibility, reliability and transferability (Merriam and Tisdell, 2016; Cohen, Manion and Morrison, 2018). Credibility was strengthened using semi-structured interviews so that participants could recount their experiences in depth, with quotations used to support findings (Merriam and Tisdell, 2016). Reliability was promoted by using open-ended questions to reduce researcher bias and ensure genuine responses to be raised (Cohen, Manion and Morrison (2018). While the small sample size and single school limited generalisability and transferability of the study, it enabled closer exploration of individual perspectives within a specific school setting (Merriam and Tisdell, 2016).

Positionality as a researcher

Throughout the study I considered how my position as researcher could affect the findings. I have some preexisting assumptions about play-based learning and children's wellbeing from developing my literature review and from my own experience working in schools. Potential researcher bias could occur due to my preexisting professional relationship with some of the teachers being interviewed. Therefore, I took a constructivist worldview using open ended questions and non-leading language to allow participants to freely express their opinions (Creswell and Creswell, 2018). This allowed me to take a reflective stance and reduce bias while recognising that each teacher held unique views based on their lived experience which would influence how they responded (Creswell and Creswell, 2018).

Ethics

Throughout the study I complied with the ethical guidelines from the British Educational Research Association (BERA, 2017). I considered gaining informed consent, and ensured confidentiality and anonymity of my participants. Permission was gained from UCL gatekeepers before embarking on the research, recruiting participants and proceeding with interviews. A fuller discussion of the ethical considerations can be found in the Appendix 1-4.

Findings and Discussion

This section presents findings from the semi-structured interviews conducted with three primary school teachers and discusses their views in relation to existing literature on play and transition to KS1. Below is a table outlining the teachers' roles and their experience of teaching.

Pseudonym	Role	Experience
Alice	Reception teacher	Second year at this school
Beth	Year 1 / 2 teacher	Eight years at this school, previous nursery experience
Connor	Year 1 / 2 teacher	Over four years in Years 1 and 2

Finding 1: The whole school values play-based learning and staff collaborate to implement it

All three teachers described how there is a shared, school-wide commitment to play-based learning which can be seen from Reception through to KS1. Alice stated that:

“all the staff here view and see the importance of the play-based approach and all are enforcing that in the classroom”

emphasising the strength of the school's collective ambition to provide play-based learning.

Beth shared that:

“we've got obviously play-based learning in foundation stage year one and year two”

and that this system is a *“strength of our school”*. Connor confirmed that play-based learning is implemented intentionally throughout the school, with staff *“thinking about the children first and foremost”* when rolling out this type of pedagogical approach. The schools approach contrasts to findings which suggest that play is often undervalued and seen as secondary to other forms of learning, despite the evidence that displays its benefits (BERA, 2017). The school appears to have a strong understanding of how play can contribute to a smooth transition process and its developmental capabilities beyond Reception (Fisher, 2020). This approach seems to reflect Nicholson's (2019) research that many teachers in England would be supportive of an increase in play-based learning.

Teachers also discussed that staff collaboration strategies were essential in maintaining the play-based approach. Alice commented that staff *“look at other classrooms between the year groups”* to gain different ideas and Beth notes that teachers will *“share ideas”* and *“share resources”*. Connor elaborated that teachers regularly meet to plan play-based provision and ask each other, *“what are you doing in yours?”*. This intentional collaboration within the school offers teachers the opportunity to build on their knowledge of play-based pedagogy and helps strengthen relationships for transition between EYFS and KS1 (Fisher, 2020). As the participants comments displayed, backing from the leadership team is crucial in providing teachers with the autonomy to implement play into the curriculum (Fisher, 2020).

However, despite this shared commitment, teachers highlighted several barriers in realising a fully play-based curriculum within their school. They expressed concerns regarding the lack of resources, large class sizes, curriculum pressures and the lack of formal policy support for the practice. Connor found that because play-based learning was not “*written down in the curriculum*” it was challenging to convince people of its vital developmental value. This mirrors wider challenges identified in research, which displays that even teachers who believe in the benefits of play-based learning feel constrained in how much they can provide (McInnes, 2021; Nicholson and Hendry, 2022).

Finding 2: Even within one school, teachers' understandings and use of play can differ

All three teachers agreed that play-based learning is valuable and the child-centred nature of the approach allowed children to more freely explore their interests. All three described how play was essential in supporting children who may not be ready for more formalised learning. However, important differences emerged between the teachers in how they understood and implemented play-based learning within their classrooms.

Alice discussed that play-based learning was a central reason for why she enjoyed working with this age group. From her perspective, she discussed how she enacted play-based learning by:

“...being able to experience a lot of interactions with children in that setting through their play, so not a structured each lesson and being able to have those interactions that are meaningful and engage in conversations, learn about their interests and just really see what

they enjoy and what makes them unhappy and then finding ways to teach them through those things rather than a set way for everyone”.

Alice's comments display her emphasis on the child-centred approach she fosters, connecting with her students through the playful interactions they experience together. She further articulated that this type of learning for children in EYFS meant “*letting them go and explore*” and that it was a “*free approach*”. This idea reflects how letting a child explore and play where they are most interested in EYFS is widely regarded as imperative in supporting social, emotional and educational development (EEF, 2025b, EYFS statutory framework, 2025b).

Connor's approach is more structured with an intentional use of scaffolding. He illustrated that from the start of Year 1, teachers model play for children:

“especially at the start of year one, we are scaffolding and modelling play, what that looks like still, what we expect children to, when they are in the role play area or they are in the sandpit, showing them what they could be doing, but not telling them what to do whilst they're there or telling them what to say”

Both Alice and Connor discussed how in their school, play-based learning is enacted in a “*hybrid continuous provision model*” (Connor), combining continuous provision, where children can freely access resources with enhanced provision, where activities are linked to the curriculum and offer an extra challenge for children (Sutherland, 2006). Connor's scaffolding strategy reflects Vygotsky's (1978) notion of ZPD, where adults can build on what children already understand to create new learning opportunities and to support

development. Therefore, Connor's approach displays carefully planned adult support combined with a classroom organised for play.

In contrast, Beth's perspective of play-based learning was more teacher-initiated, suggesting that children must do "*a little bit of work with me*" before they play, as she has to "*cover the curriculum*" (Beth). While she seems to support play and acknowledges that

"Children really struggle to focus for a longer period of time. They're not ready to do formal learning, formal writing."

Her opinion of play and learning in Year 1 is more separated, with formalised learning coming before child-led play. Beth's challenges in balancing curriculum objectives with play seems to mirror how teachers in England often face curriculum constraints, meaning even when they want to create more play-based opportunities, they feel pressure to focus on completing formal goals first (Nicholson, 2019). The difference in how teachers enact play in their classrooms illustrates a potential gap between what research says and the ability for teachers to practice play.

Overall, all three teachers are committed to variations of play-based learning but see their roles as teachers differently. Here certain teachers seem aware of the value in letting children lead their learning while others view the classroom as a teacher-led space.

Finding 3: Play is used to support learning and development across EYFS and KS1

All three teachers emphasised that play-based learning supports children's development in a wide range of curriculum areas such as maths, writing and physical skills, rather than being separate from academic learning.

Beth commented that play-based learning supports children's "*cognitive development*", "*problem solving*" and "*memory*" while Connor also highlighted how play can "*promote creativity*" and "*develops language skills*". These views align with research that displays how play-based learning can support cognitive and social development (Whitebread et al, 2017), conveying its importance within KS1.

Additionally, the teachers discussed how children's fine and gross motor skills could be improved through play-based learning. Beth provided examples of how play can help with "*the gross and fine motor skills when they build something, it helps them to balance, it helps them to count. They are more spatially aware, fine motor skills as well when they thread or when they cut*".

This is supported by the EEF (2024) which mentions how playful mark making, art, physical activity and using the hands during play can strengthen children's later ability to write. As research articulates, and as the teachers display here, play supports development in various social, physical and curriculum-based areas (Briggs and Hansen, 2012).

This school's approach contrasts with findings that many schools divert away from play as children enter KS1 in favour of formal learning objectives (Samuelsson and Carlsson, 2008; Howe, 2016). Teachers described how they integrated the curriculum into their play-based spaces. In Alice's view, play activities are usually linked to "*literacy and maths*" and that "*It's a really important way that children learn and not just cutting that off after they're out of the early years and into key stage one*".

This reflects researchers concerns regarding the discontinuity between EYFS and KS1 in the reduction of play (Nicholson, 2019; McInnes, 2021). Connor shared that children could apply what they are learning through play such as with the "*top trumps*" game where children can

practice reading “*three digit numbers*”. As the teachers indicate, research also suggests that purposeful play can merge both curriculum objectives with child-led learning and the interests of the child (Nicholson and Hendry, 2022, Ofsted, 2024).

The concept of child autonomy was also frequently raised. Beth and Alice spoke about how children were encouraged to choose which activities they wanted to do and to learn through their own interests. Beth argues that play means learning is “*not just what I dictate*” and Alice noted that children can access play-based activities “*when they want to*”. Their style of teaching mirrors the EYFS Framework (DfE, 2025b) that children should be learning through play and exploration, extended here into KS1. Research conveys that allowing children to be able to choose where they next go to play and learn means they will be more likely to actively participate and engage in the classroom (Moore, 2014, McInnes, 2021).

Finding 4: Play is used as a tool in aiding emotional and social wellbeing during transition to KS1

All the teachers in the study acknowledged that play was a tool which could support children's emotional and social wellbeing during the transition to Year 1, emphasising that access to familiar play-based areas helps children feel confident and can help to settle them into a new environment. Alice argued that anxiety eases when children

“are in an environment doing something that they are enjoying so they can kind of focus on that”

while Beth mentioned that children can “*make sense of their emotions*” as “*play-based learning helps them to regulate*”.

Connor claims that:

“We really are mindful the fact that they need time to feel comfortable by playing and that is our probably our first and foremost tool to get them to feel comfortable is to be able to play just in a new environment.”, (Connor)

These perspectives align with research that shows how play supports emotional regulation and wellbeing during early childhood (Bodrova, Germeroth and Leong, 2013, Whitebread et. al., 2017).

Additionally, play was also described as crucial in allowing children to develop social skills and friendships. All three teachers commented that children who enter Year 1 with preexisting friendships formed in Reception experienced a smoother transition with less anxiety. Alice described that when children would transition to Year 1 from her class they were *“able to feel that strength in the friendship”*, enabling them to be more comfortable in a new environment when there was some continuity of friendships. Alice mentions that friendships are supported by play because children build a *“common interest”*, a basis upon which to interact further. Beth shared that *“with language, they communicate with their friends.”*, connecting to research that play can support cognition and communication development (Whitebread et. Al. 2017; Nicholson, 2019). The teachers' perspectives mirror McInnes (2021) argument that play is still important in Year 1 to continue developing social skills. They reflected findings from Nicholson (2019) and Moore (2014) who display how emotional wellbeing can be supported through play and friendships during transition, for instance that play means children can

“build relationships, they understand taking turns, they understand that somebody else has different views on things” (Beth). Her comments demonstrate the importance of nurturing play as it can facilitate the strengthening of social skills and the development of interpersonal understanding between peers.

Connor was supportive that play has social benefits, stating that *“it develops their social skills”* but emphasised the importance of continuity between EYFS and Year 1 more. He argued that play

“supports their emotional wellbeing. I suppose it helps that transition because without play, they would think, what on earth is this?”,

illustrating that without play the move to Year 1 would feel abrupt, meaning children could feel increased insecurity in an unknown environment which could impact their wellbeing.

This connects to Fisher’s (2011) argument that there is often discontinuity between EYFS and Year 1 as a sudden reduction in play occurs. These teachers seem keen to prolong play for as long as possible to strengthen children's emotional resilience, confidence and wellbeing.

Finding 5: Children can find the transition to KS1 challenging and teachers use supportive strategies to help

Even though the school offers a play-based approach, all three teachers stated that transition to Year 1 can still be challenging for some children with increased educational expectations and changes in their environment (Wildenger and McIntyre, 2011; Jun, Meissel and Cooper, 2025). Teachers highlighted the challenges associated with increased formalised learning, which had reduced opportunities for play before the school introduced its shift towards play-based learning across KS1. This indicates teachers saw the struggles children were facing and were able to construct their teaching and classrooms to provide much smoother transitions. Alice mentioned that

“Some aren't really too phased, other children do find it quite challenging and can become quite anxious by it”

and that children can feel “*uncertainty*” during this time. This duality in emotional security the class can feel is reflected in research that implies students can feel both excited and nervous when in transitional stages in school (Jun, Meissel and Cooper, 2025).

Another major theme addressed by the teachers was the discontinuity that can occur between Reception and Year 1, even within a school which embraces play. While the school has tried to support this as much as possible, there are inevitably still changes in the formality of learning. Beth notes that in EYFS it is “*very free play*” but that in Year 1 children must “*sit*” and “*do the curriculum*”. She also recounts how children seem “*bored because they lose interest*” and that “*school is no longer a lovely place where you can go*” when more formalised learning is introduced. This supports Fisher’s (2011) argument of the pedagogical discontinuity present in many schools during the transition to Year 1. Connor reflected that

this issue occurred much more previously, before the school adopted its play-based approach, that

“when I joined, it was very much Foundation stage is its own entity and year one. They learn English, they learn math, they learn this subject, they learn that, and it was sat at tables”.

Connors comments convey the significance of the shift within the school since he began, from a formal, structure-oriented and passive approach to learning to a more play-based approach.

Increased learning expectations create another challenge for young children. Connor explained that there is an *“increased expectation... around attention”* and that children are required to become more *“independent to record what they are doing”* (Connor). This mirrors a wider concern that KS1 is too formalised too quickly, with literacy and maths a large focus in early primary (Ofsted, 2018). While this could be rewarding in introducing children to more challenging concepts, Beth says that Year 1 becomes *“very busy”* with the vast number of subjects such as formal handwriting, phonics and maths, meaning children *“completely lose their enthusiasm”*. As Nicholson (2019) found, teachers in England often struggle to balance the national curriculum expectations with play in their classrooms. Additionally, as the teachers imply, Reception is often seen as a preparation stage for Year 1 and yet the abrupt reduction in play does not seem to set up children well as they begin formal learning (Evans, 2025).

Furthermore, within this school there are some changes in environment and the structure of learning which teachers expressed. Connor described that the restriction of the *“outdoor space”* can be challenging for children who benefited from movement and playing in the

outdoors, going there whenever they liked in Reception. As Dunlop and Fabian (2007) and Huser, Dockett, and Perry (2016) described, the change in environment and any unsuccessful bridging between Reception and Year 1 mean children can lack confidence and engagement, becoming a potential barrier to learning and development.

In response to the challenges witnessed, the teachers highlighted various practical strategies which helped children successfully transition to Year 1. In Reception, Alice avoids talking about transition “*too much at first*” to avoid unnecessary, premature anxieties and later on in the year arranges for children to meet “*the new teacher*” and see “*the new classroom*”. She also mentions that children create “*passports*” which are designed to help the new Year 1 teacher get to know the children more closely, understanding their specific needs. Beth lists a couple of strategies she has including “*a lot of transition meetings before they come to year one*”, and “*getting to know the children and knowing what their interests and what their personalities are like*”. Both Beth and Connor highlight the importance of getting to know both the children and parents well as they transition to Year 1. Beth discussed how she visits Reception for “*stories and a bit of play*” and Connor describing how “*the teachers spend up to about 5 weeks going into their new class, getting to know them*”. These strategies align with research that promotes teachers and students becoming used to each other, building familiarity for children so the transition does not feel as abrupt and unknown (Fisher, 2020; Quirk and Pettett, 2021). These familiarisation techniques are supported by research that suggests the importance of well-planned transition to avoid negative consequences such as emotional and academic difficulties which could progress throughout school (Nicholson, 2019).

The engagement of parents was also displayed as a central strategy. Beth says the schoolteachers “*work closely with parents. We send out newsletters*” and Connor explains that “*We also offer like welcome to year one and year two. That's more for parents to know that that is still available for them*”. These transition support strategies reflect Fisher’s (2020) research that forming close connections with parents, teachers and children can support effective transitions as children begin to adapt to a new learning environment.

Conclusion

The study found that in relation to the research question, literature and views of the participants, play-based learning is perceived by teachers as a crucial factor in supporting children's wellbeing and transition to KS1.

Throughout the study, teachers repeatedly recognised play-based learning as a supportive pedagogical tool that can help reduce worry and anxiety for children transitioning from Reception to Year 1. They also commented that play can support children with emotional regulation and in allowing friendships to form. While all teachers valued play, they implemented it in different ways through both child-led practice and structured teacher-led approaches. Additionally, throughout the study the effectiveness of play-based learning was shown to be influenced by factors such as school wide recognition of the benefits of play-based learning and if teachers could implement play appropriately while faced with curriculum constraints.

Overall, this study supports the claim that play-based learning can help bridge the gap between Reception and Year 1 and can contribute to increased wellbeing and learning outcomes. However, there were various limitations in the study. As the study focused on a single school that had already incorporated play into their ethos, the transferability of findings may be limited, a challenge in how it can be applied to a wider array of more traditional schools. Additionally, as I relied on semi-structured interviews alone, the responses I received were personal, self-reported insights which might not have displayed the true nature of play within the classroom.

Future research on this topic could build upon the study by expanding the scope to a wider range of primary schools which could create conditions for comparison, as the small sample of this study limits generalisability. Additionally, using classroom observations could allow for a more holistic understanding of the way play is implemented. Longer term research on the effects of a play-based pedagogy and its role in supporting children's wellbeing, learning and transitions could also be explored to understand how the practice manifests over time.

In summary, this body of work contributes to the expanding field of research which suggests that play-based learning should continue into KS1. Although there are various policy and curriculum restraints, it has been recognised that play is an important way in which children can experience security in transition, build relationships and develop their learning in a way that sets them up for success throughout their education.

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Appendices

Appendix 1: BA Education Studies Dissertation Ethics Application Form 2025-2026

Name:

Title of project (the details of your project will be provided by your research proposal).

Supporting children's wellbeing during school transitions through play: Practitioners' perceptions on approaching children's entry to Key Stage 1 (KS1) in England.

Confirmation of Informed Consent. Will you gain the informed consent of participants? How will this be obtained?

Firstly, I will gain consent from the Head and deputy head of the school before I contact other staff members. To gain informed consent from my participants, who will all be above the age of 18, I will ensure they understand what my study entails by providing them with an information sheet which will explain my study aims, how the data will be used and their rights as a participant. I will also ask them to sign a consent form before I conduct the interviews.

I will provide the information sheet and consent form both when I initially email the participants and also bring physical copies when I interview them in person. I will offer a chance for the participants to ask any questions about the study and give a verbal explanation of the research if needed. I will convey that consent is ongoing throughout the interview process by letting participants know they can pause or stop the interview at any time, can skip questions and can withdraw their consent and data at any time. I will remind them of this before, during and after the interview in the debrief regarding withdrawal.

Will you guarantee the anonymity and confidentiality of your participants? How will this be achieved?

I will ensure anonymity as much as possible by using pseudonyms for all participants and any individuals mentioned such as students or other staff members. I will anonymise the school's name and ensure I have checked that any information that could potentially identify the school or people within the school be removed or changed to reduce the risk of participants being identified.

Furthermore, confidentiality will be maintained by stating who has access to data during the research process. All interviews will be conducted by myself, the only researcher. The audio

recordings, transcripts and any other written notes will only be accessed by the researcher and university supervisor. Any other members of staff and the school leadership team will not have access to this data.

However, a limitation of the study is that complete anonymity may not be guaranteed because of the small-scale style of the study and the school context which means staff members and school leadership might be able to speculate on the identity of the participants. The research questions will be designed so they focus on play-based teaching practices and the transition to KS1. Participants will not be asked to disclose anything that might harm their role at the school, their relationship with the leadership team or the reputation of the school itself.

Participants will be able to view a draft and the final dissertation if they wish and I will let them know this before the interview. This is so participants can decide if they are satisfied with the level of anonymity and will allow them to withdraw their consent if they wish. Participants will be made aware that the final dissertation will be accessible to the university assessors and could be read by others in the UCL library database. They will also be told if the final dissertation is shared with school leadership.

Storage of Data.

Where will the data be stored? What measures will you take to ensure the safe storage of data.

I will store the data digitally in a secure password protected university cloud (OneDrive). I will obtain voice recordings through teams meeting recording and will upload the transcripts from these to my OneDrive account immediately after the interview. I will immediately delete the recordings after this. My OneDrive is password protected and will only be viewed by myself and my supervisor at my discretion. Pseudonyms will be used during transcription.

How long will the data and records be kept for and in what format?

The audio recordings and transcripts will be stored on my password protected OneDrive account. The data will only be accessible to myself and my university supervisor when necessary. I will keep the data for the academic year after submission and then delete it in accordance with Data Protection Regulations.

Confirm that all personal data will be stored and processed in compliance with the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). (see guidance on Moodle).

Yes

Are there particular features of the proposed work which may raise ethical concerns or add to the complexity of ethical decision making? If so, please outline how you will deal with these.

It is important that you demonstrate your awareness of potential risks or harm that may arise as a result of your research. You should then demonstrate that you have considered ways to minimise the likelihood and impact of each potential harm that you have identified. Please be as specific as possible in describing the ethical issues you will have to address. Please consider / address ALL issues that may apply.

Ethical concerns may include, but not be limited to, the following areas:

- Methods - Sampling - Recruitment - Gatekeepers - Informed consent - Potentially vulnerable participants - Safeguarding/child protection - Sensitive topics	- International research - Risks to participants and/or researchers - Confidentiality/Anonymity - Disclosures/limits to confidentiality - Data storage and security both during and after the research (including transfer, sharing, encryption, protection) - Reporting - Dissemination and use of findings (e.g. considerations related to whether you will share your dissertation research with participants)
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The research explores teachers' perspectives of play-based learning and how it can support children's transition from EYFS to KS1 using qualitative, semi-structured interviews with school staff. The main ethical considerations of the study includes informed consent, power dynamics, confidentiality, safeguarding and the discussion of sensitive professional topics. Ethics approval will be gained from the university before data collection starts and will be conducted in accordance with university ethical guidelines as well as BERA's ethical guidelines for educational research.

the study is small scale and focused on one school context, there is a risk of participants being identifiable due to views expressed or context given regarding play-based learning techniques at the school and transition strategies for example. This topic could be professionally sensitive due to varying and individual ways in which teachers approach their own practice. Participation will be on a voluntary basis, so there is no pressure to participate. The school leaders such as the head and deputy head will act as gatekeepers and I will need to gain their consent to be able to enter the school and before I individually contact other teachers for interviews. Teachers will be informed that if they do not wish to participate, it will not affect their professional role or relationships in the school.

thermore, while the research does not directly involve discussions with children, teachers will comment on transition practices which could include discussion of student needs and behaviour and readiness for KS1. I will design my interview questions so that only the general practice of the teacher and their professional judgment regarding the subject is discussed as much as possible, rather than focusing on individual children in the school. If any identifiable details, such as staff, students, or the school name is mentioned, it will be anonymised during transcription and within my final dissertation. This will help to create a focus on pedagogy and practice within my research rather than individual children and their specific needs and challenges.

reover, safeguarding and child protection is relevant in my study because of the school-based nature of my research and interviews. The interview questions won't ask about specific safeguarding issues as this is not the focus of the research. If a safeguarding concern emerges in the interview or I witness a safeguarding concern when I am in the school, I as the researcher will follow the school's safeguarding policy. I will report any concerns in a timely manner to the designated safeguarding lead (DSL). If a staff member says something that may be a concern for their own wellbeing during the interview, I will pause the interview and check that they are ok or if they need any help. I will contact my dissertation supervisor if I have this concern.

ddition, the research topic of play-based learning and its role in the transition to KS1 may include sensitive professional discussions surrounding teachers concerns about certain policies, curriculum content and workload pressures or opposing opinions between EYFS and KS1. I will carry out the interview with care and sensitivity and remind participants about their right to withdraw, to skip questions or pause the interview without needing a reason to do so. I will offer a debrief after the interview so participants can ask questions or raise concerns and so they feel comfortable.

ally, I will also consider the reporting and dissemination of my findings. I will use anonymised quotes when reporting my findings and will not reveal any school members' names, class group identifiers, student names, or school name. I will inform my participants that the dissertation research is only for academic purposes, and they will be offered a chance to review my findings or draft dissertation if they wish.

Please attach the consent form and information sheet templates along with this form if you are undertaking empirical research. This is a prerequisite to gaining ethical approval for your project.

I have read, understood and will abide by the BERA set of guidelines (if you are adhering to a different set of guidelines- e.g. British Sociological Association, state here).

Yes: yes

No:

I confirm that to the best of my knowledge:

The above information is correct and that this is a full description of the ethics issues that may arise in the course of this project.

Student's signature:

Final Approval by Supervisor. It should be noted that the initial submission of this form (as an appendix to the final version of your research proposal) is likely to lead to suggested amendments by your supervisor (e.g. requests for clarification, suggestions for considerations of ethical issues that may have been overlooked etc.). Once all relevant considerations have been sufficiently addressed your supervisor will sign below.

Supervisor's Approval

I am satisfied the relevant ethical considerations have been addressed:

Supervisors Signature: Kate O'Shaughnessy

Date: 22nd January 2026

Any Further comments:

Once the above approval by the supervisor (1st reviewer) has been granted, the signed form must be uploaded by the student on the Ethics Approval Submission box **at least one week before you plan to begin data collection:**

<https://moodle.ucl.ac.uk/mod/turnitintooltwo/view.php?id=7668602>

The form will then be considered by Prof Mark Freeman as 2nd reviewer. This form must be approved by 1st and 2nd reviewer before data collection can commence. See the ethics tab on Moodle for further details.

Appendix 2: Information sheet for participants

1/02/26-28/02/26

Information sheet for practitioners

My name is and I am inviting you to take in part in my research project, 'Supporting children's wellbeing during school transitions through play: Practitioners' perceptions on approaching children's entry to Key Stage 1 (KS1) in England'.

I am a student at the University College London (UCL) in the Institute of Education (IOE) and am researching play-based learning in EYFS and KS1 and how teachers conduct smooth transitions for children to KS1 for my dissertation. Studying at the UCL IOE, ranked 1st in the world for education as a subject, means I have come to understand how to conduct high quality research and have been able to access some of the most prestigious research around education practices. UCL will be funding this project.

My areas of interest in the extension of play into KS1 and ensuring positive transitions for students stems from my ambition to be a teacher, wanting to understand how best to support children who will come under my care. The modules I have taken at university link directly to early childhood education approaches which is also a major area of interest for me.

I very much hope that you would like to take part. This information sheet will try and answer any questions you might have about the project, but please do not hesitate to contact me if there is anything else you would like to know.

I will be following the BERA's Ethical Guidelines for Educational Research which you may review here: <https://www.bera.ac.uk/publication/ethical-guidelines-for-educational-research-fifth-edition-2024>

Who is carrying out the research?

Lalani Chandra-Stewart, UCL 3rd year Education Studies BA student

Why are we doing this research?

I am aiming to answer this research question within my dissertation:

- How do teachers in EYFS and Year 1 perceive the role of play-based learning in promoting children's wellbeing during the transition to Year One in a Primary school in Eastern England?

I believe this research area is highly relevant in the current conversation within education development and learning how best to support young children through major transitions.

Why am I being invited to take part?

I will be interviewing a range of staff members. As a participant, you will contribute to my research by informing me of your perspectives regarding the transition children experience to Year 1, how you prepare children for this, how you feel this transition impacts children's

wellbeing and how you view play-based learning. I will use the interview recordings and create transcripts which I will then analyse to discuss within my dissertation.

What will happen if I choose to take part?

If you choose to take part, you will be invited to one individual interview with me. This will last about 20-30 minutes and will take place at a time and location convenient to you, either at school or online.

The interview will be semi structured, meaning that I will ask a set of open-ended questions and you are free to answer regarding your experiences in as much detail as you'd like. With your permission, I will record the interview so I can transcribe it later. You will not be identified in any way in transcripts or my dissertation writing.

Questions asked during the interview will focus on discussing your perceptions and experiences with play-based learning and how this links to transition and wellbeing for children from EYFS to KS1.

You won't be asked to complete any tests or additional activities beyond this interview. You do not need to answer any questions you do not wish to and we can stop the interview at any time you would like without needing a reason to do so.

Will anyone know I have been involved?

All information I receive will remain strictly confidential. Your name, the school and any other identifying terms used will be removed and replaced with pseudonyms in transcripts and my written dissertation.

However, as this study is taking place in one school and includes a small number of staff, complete anonymity can't be guaranteed. There is a possibility that some school staff and leadership team might be able to recognise comments made or context given and speculate about who the participants are.

Only myself and my supervisor will have access to the audio recordings and transcripts. They will be stored remotely on a secure, password protected one drive account and will not be shared with the school.

If you do share information during the interview that raises a safeguarding concern to me, suggesting a child may be at risk of harm, then I am legally required to report this to the appropriate safeguarding contact. If this should happen, I would aim to discuss this with you if possible.

Therefore, aside from safeguarding responsibilities, all other information such as your participation and responses will remain confidential and anonymous.

Could there be problems for me if I take part?

It is not expected that taking part in this research will cause any significant issues.

However, as the interview does involve discussing your professional opinions and experiences you might feel unsure or uncomfortable about answering certain questions. You

do not need to answer any question you prefer not to, and we can stop or pause the interview at any time without you giving a reason.

The interview will take place in a respectful and conversational manner, and I will take care to not ask questions that seem to evaluate your practice in any way.

If you feel uncomfortable during the discussion you are welcome to express this and can pause the interview or drop out altogether if you wish.

What will happen to the results of the research?

The results of the research will be used in my undergraduate dissertation at UCL. All data will be stored in a secure OneDrive account and will be deleted after submission of my final dissertation. If any publication of the work occurs, all identifying information will be replaced with pseudonyms. The dissertation will be viewed by the assessors and will be available in the UCL library system but will not be disseminated further.

If you'd like to view a summary of the findings once I have completed the research, you can request this, and I will email it to you.

Once I have completed my transcriptions, all audio recordings will be deleted.

Do I have to take part?

Taking part in this research is voluntary. It is your choice whether you would like to participate, and choosing not to take part will have no negative consequences for you. Your decision will not affect your role or any relationship with the researcher or UCL.

If you do choose to take part, you are free to withdraw from the study up until the submission of the dissertation, by May 1st. You do not need to give a reason for withdrawal. At any point you decide to withdraw, no data collected will be used in the final dissertation. You can also skip any questions you prefer not to answer.

I hope that if you choose to participate you will find it a positive and reflective experience, but there is no requirement to continue if you no longer wish to be involved.

Data Protection Privacy Notice

The controller for this project will be University College London (UCL). The UCL Data Protection Officer provides oversight of UCL activities involving the processing of

personal data, and can be contacted at data-protection@ucl.ac.uk

This 'local' privacy notice sets out the information that applies to this particular study.

Further information on how UCL uses participant information from research studies can be found in our 'general' privacy notice for participants in research studies [here](#).

The information that is required to be provided to participants under data protection legislation (GDPR and DPA 2018) is provided across both the 'local' and 'general' privacy notices. The lawful basis that will be used to process any personal data is:

'Public task' for personal data and 'Research purposes' for special category data.

Your personal data will be processed so long as it is required for the research project. If we are able to anonymise or pseudonymise the personal data you provide we will undertake this, and will endeavour to minimise the processing of personal data wherever possible.

If you are concerned about how your personal data is being processed, or if you would like to contact us about your rights, please contact UCL in the first instance at dataprotection@ucl.ac.uk.

Contact for further information

If you have any further questions before you decide whether to take part, you can reach me at

If you would like to be involved, please complete the following consent form and return to by Wednesday 11th February 2026.

Thank you very much for taking the time to read this information sheet.

Appendix 3: Participant Consent Form

If you are happy to participate in this study please complete this consent form by ticking each item, as appropriate, and return to the research team via the contact details below:

- 1) I confirm that I have read and understood this information sheet, and have had the opportunity to consider the information, ask questions, and have had these questions adequately answered. ☐
- 2) I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I am free to withdraw at any time, without giving any reason. ☐
- 3) I know that I can refuse to answer any or all of the questions and that I can withdraw from the interview at any point. ☐
- 4) I agree for the interview to be recorded, and that recordings will be kept secure and destroyed at the end of the project. I know that all data will be kept under the terms of the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). ☐
- 5) I agree that small direct quotes may be used in reports (these will be anonymised). ☐
- 6) I understand that in exceptional circumstances anonymity and confidentiality would have to be broken, for example, if it was felt that practice was putting children at risk, or there were concerns regarding professional misconduct. In these circumstances advice would be sought from a senior manager from another local authority who will advise us as to the appropriate course of action and as to whether we need to inform the authority of what you have told us. ☐

Name:.....
.....

Signature:
Date:

Name of researcher:

Signature:

Date:

Appendix 4: Interview questions

- 1. Can you tell me about your role and experience working with children in Reception or Year 1?**

Follow up:

- How long have you worked with this age group
- what do you enjoy most about the role?

- 2. From your experience, what do children tend to find most challenging when transitioning from Reception to Year 1?**

Follow up:

- Are these challenges more social, emotional, or learning-related?
- Do some children find the transition easier than others? Why?

3. What does the term “play-based learning” mean to you in the context of Reception and Year 1?

Follow up:

- What does this look like in your own classroom or practice?
- What do you see as the benefits or limitations of a play-based approach?

4. In what ways, if any, do you think play supports children’s emotional wellbeing during the transition to Year 1?

Follow up:

- Can you think of an example of a child who benefited from this type of learning?
- What changes do you notice when play opportunities are increased or reduced?

5. How do you think play-based approaches support children’s learning as they move into Year 1?

Follow up:

- Are there particular skills that play supports at this stage?
- How intentional is the use of play-based learning within the transition process in your school?

6. How does the role of play change as children move from Reception into Year 1, and how do staff work together around this?

Follow up:

- Are ideas about play shared or discussed between EYFS and Year 1 staff?
- Do EYFS and KS1 staff view play in similar or different ways?

7. Is there anything else you would like to share about play, transition, or children’s wellbeing that you feel is important to discuss?